serait le maximum à Hombourg, on pourrait, en 3 mois, gagner 400,000 francs. En supposant de nombreux revers, il serait toujours possible de gagner dans la saison 150,000 f.[39] — Pour jouer ce jeu il faut 153 pièces, c'est à dire à Aix 51 thalers. — J'avais proposé cette combinaison à M. Oslanski qui m'avait promis la somme; je suis venu à Aix comptant sur lui; mais il se trouve en ce moment dans l'impossibilitié de le faire. Il me donne bien des espérances lointaines, mais je ne puis les attendre dans la position où je suis. — J'ai donc pensé à vous, Monsieur, et si vous vouliez bien me confier cette somme, je suis convaincu que j'obtiendrais, pour vous et pour moi de beaux résultats. Vous me rendriez un grand service et c'est à ce titre surtout que je vous la demande. — Je n'insiste pas du reste; il y a là une double question: celle de la possibilité dont vous seul êtes juge; puis une question de confiance que vous apprécierez. — Je vous prie de me donner votre reponse d'ici au 19, si toutefois cette lettre vous parvient

[39] Mr. G. William Bergquist is the author of the following note:

The "system" mentioned in this letter is what is known as a progression or "martingale." These systems are not concerned with the particular numbers or places on which one should place's one's bets, but rather with the procedure as to the amount of the bets, according to whether the bets are won or lost.

Most gamblers maintain that the past does not affect the future and the chances of winning a bet may not be affected by a previous loss, but if the following bet is won, the previous loss is wiped out. Progressions in betting are based on this theory and it is considered advisable to increase one's bet after a loss, in order that one's wins will balance or exceed the losses. The fallacy in this theory lies in the assumption that one can not always lose.

The simplest progression is the system of doubling the stake after each loss. The stakes in the event of a succession of losses would be: 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32. Each win would give a net profit of one unit. It would seem that the system mentioned in the letter was either this one or the so-called Montante Stanislas. Such systems are usually used in conjunction with betting on the "simple chances" in Roulette, namely: odd or even, black or red, first 18 numbers or last 18 numbers. All these chances pay even money. That is to say you win an amount equal to the amount of your stake.

The systems used vary in their details as to the amount the bet is increased after each loss and the number of times a certain amount is wagered. They are all supposedly based on rough laws of mathematical probabilities, but all scientific investigators have insisted that they are based on fallacies and, if adhered to, will result eventually in ruin. What some of the more conservative ones often do is to prolong the play at the table with a minimum of loss.

Insufficient details are given in the letter as to how the bets are to be made in the system mentioned. Obviously, the writer was not going to disclose his secret in its entirety. It is difficult to translate accurately since words are used with very special meanings, intelligible only to a gambler. It is clear that he proposes to play the black or red, for he says, when he hits upon it on one color, he changes to the other. This probably means when he wins on red he switches to black. This is in accordance with the gambler's dictum, "A change to black is imminent."

Briefly, as near as I can make out, the writer's system consists of making his first stake three francs (the unit) or any multiple of that. If he wins, he will continue to play the same stake until he loses. After his first loss, he adds two units to his stake. If he loses again, he adds two more units and continues to do so until he wins. When he wins, he continues to play the same stake he won with until he loses again. His next stake will be increased by two units. This continues until he has increased his stakes in this manner 19 times which would bring it to 39. No one but the writer knows what the modifications are. No doubt the absolute certainty(?) of winning depends upon these modifications.

Generated on 2020-09-15 23:23 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112401
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN